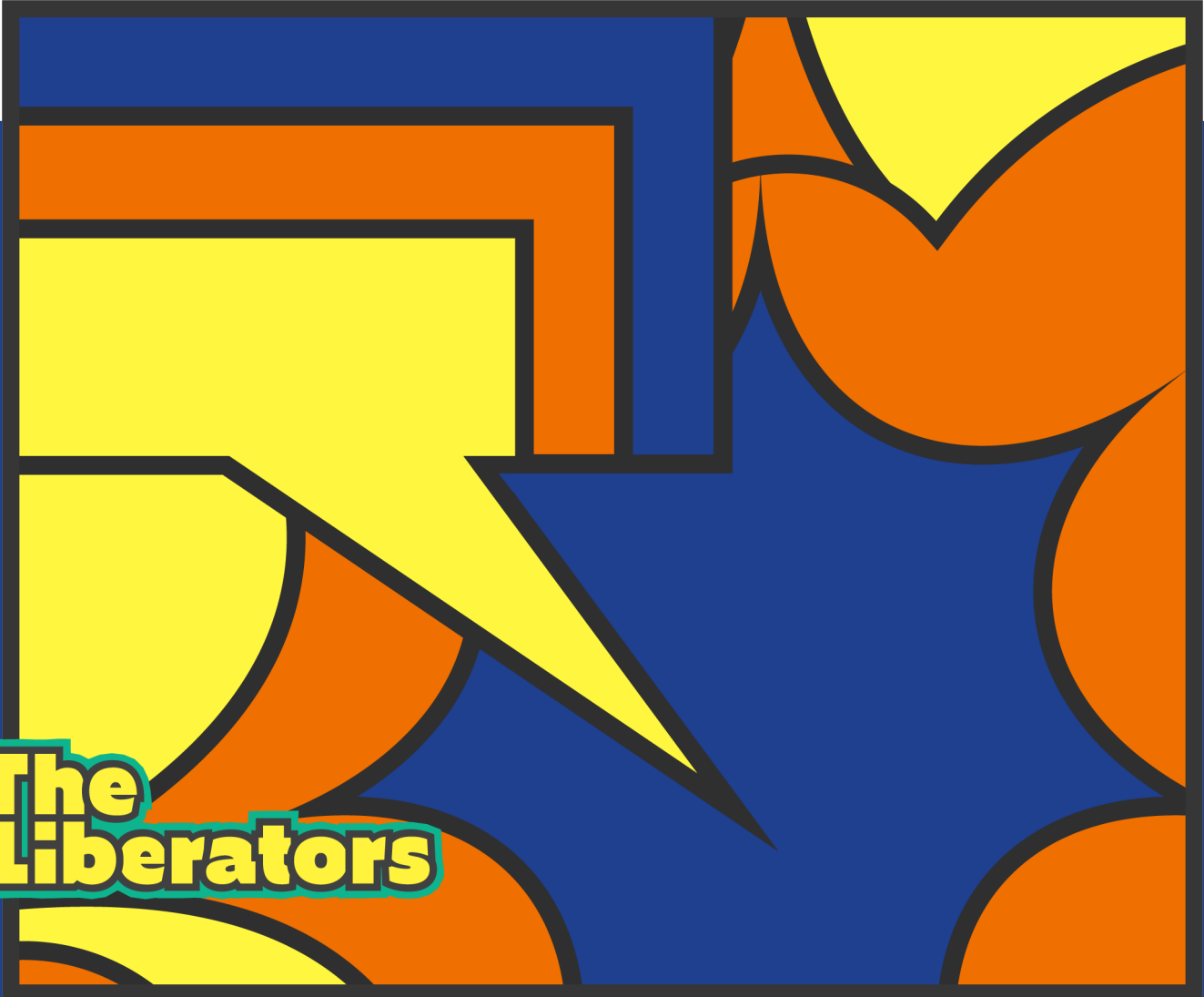


Create Product Strategies Together With Stakeholders

Respond more quickly to future challenges by creating and shaping product strategies together with your stakeholders



**The
Liberators**

Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there!

There is little point to Scrum when you don't involve stakeholders. Yet, many Scrum teams struggle to involve their stakeholders, and that makes this one of the core symptoms of Zombie Scrum. For some, involving one or two internal stakeholders seems to be enough. For others, stakeholders can only be involved when the entire product is done. But without their feedback, how can you be sure that what you're building is the right thing?

We designed this workshop to help you clarify the success criteria of the product and what the Scrum team and its stakeholders can do to support that success.

With this workshop, you become familiar with the Liberating Structures 'Nine Whys' to clarify the purpose of the product, 'Critical Uncertainties' to develop product strategies, '1-2-4-ALL' to define activities for the robust and hedging strategies, and '15% Solutions' to identify personal next steps.

Give it and let us know how it went!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow

Step 1: Opening

 2 min

Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of The Product With Nine Whys

  30 min

Step 3: Develop Strategies With Critical Uncertainties

  80 min

Step 4: Define Activities For The Most Valuable Strategies With 1-2-4-ALL

  30 min

Step 5: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

  15 min

Step 6: Closing

 3 min

Total duration

 160 min

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Critical Uncertainties can feel overwhelming. You can manage and experience its power by doing it step-by-step

Impact On Survival



A clear purpose and a variety of product strategies to quickly respond to future challenges are essential for all Scrum teams.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. We've successfully scaled it up to 100 participants (both virtually and in-person) without significant issues.

Intended Audience

The invitations and steps for this particular string are aimed at Scrum teams and their stakeholders. We highly recommend that, in addition to your team, you invite a group of stakeholders that represents the diversity of the people with a stake in your product.

It is important to invite actual stakeholders. By that we mean; people who have an actual stake in your work as a team, either because they invest significant amounts of time and/or money in it. An actual stakeholder is someone who clearly gains something when you deliver good work and loses something when you don't. Everyone else is your audience. While they may have opinions about your work, they have no personal stake in it.

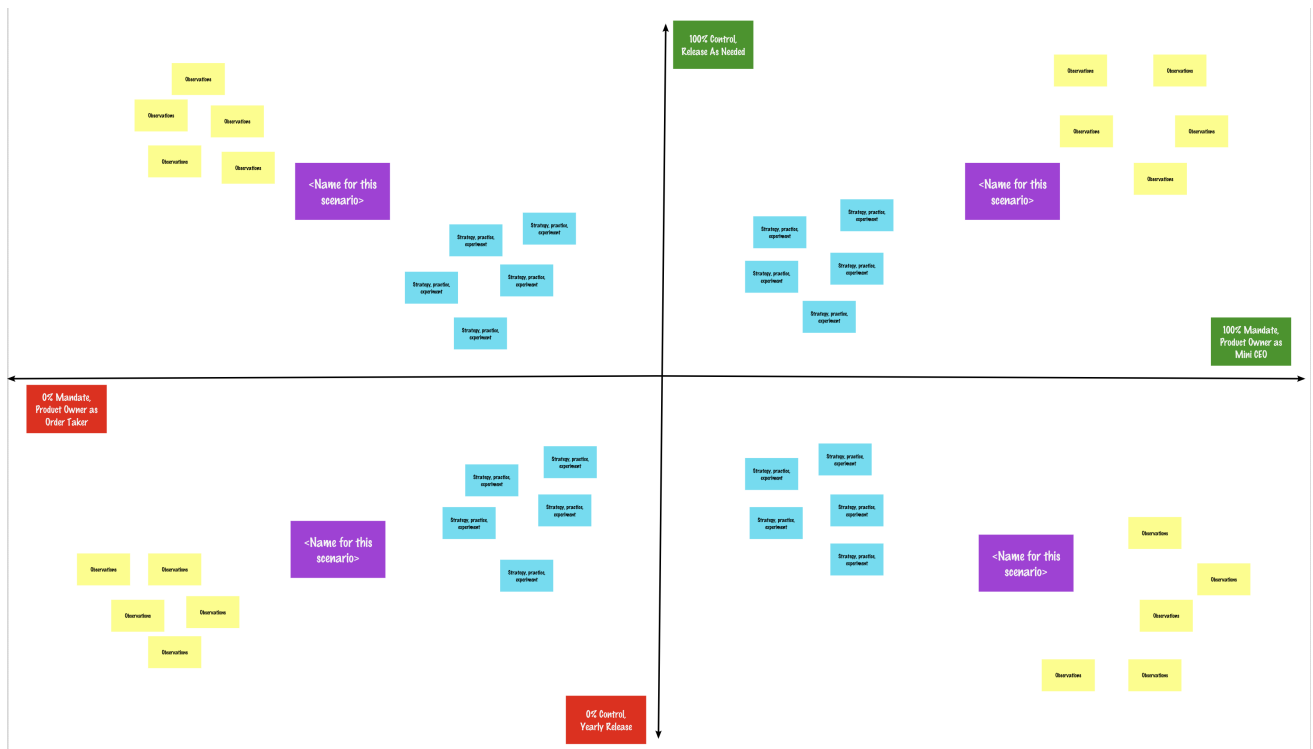
Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Material

- Prepare basic slides or a virtual whiteboard to collect your insights.
- The illustration below is an example of a Critical Uncertainties template in Mural. This allows you to gather insights and ideas from the entire group. Make sure to have this template available at the start of the session. The names we included for the axes are examples, you don't have to use them.





Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.

Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of The Product With Nine Whys

"[Start with Why](#)" is the title of a well-known book by Simon Sinek. It isn't any different for the product your Scrum team is building. Here too, it is important to start by answering the question of why it exists. If this purpose is appealing, people will enjoy being part of the team. The Liberating Structure [Nine Whys](#) is a great way to think about this with your team and its stakeholders. It starts from personal motivations and reasons and builds to the start of a shared purpose.

Invitation

"Our product is valuable, important, or desirable to me or to our stakeholders because ..."

Steps

1.  Individually, ask everyone (Scrum team and stakeholders) to compile a list of what (will) make(s) the product valuable to them.
2.  Provide an overview of the steps that are coming up so that people know what to expect once they're in their breakouts.
3.  Invite everyone to form pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Ideally, the stakeholders pair up with someone from the Scrum team. In the breakouts, people interview each other in turns, 4 min each, about their list. Interviewers only ask "Why is that (item/entire list) important for you?" while taking notes.
4.  Invite pairs to join another pair in new breakouts. In there, the pairs exchange notes and notice patterns about why people are part of this Scrum team. In the final minutes, ask the groups to complete the sentence "Our product is valuable because ...".
5.  Back in the main channel, each group briefly presents its purpose statement. Together, pick one that jumps out. Or just notice patterns across the statements.

Examples

- Our product is valuable, important, or desirable because it allows teams to continuously inspect their work as a team and improve their process accordingly;
- Our product is valuable, important, or desirable because it encourages a healthier lifestyle by making it easy for hikers to inspect how many steps they walk on a daily basis;

Our Findings

- Groups can easily get stuck in the process of coming up with a great purpose statement. It is important to work empirically here, too. Start with a quick and raw version and improve it over time as you learn more about this meetup.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Make the Purpose of Your Work Together Clear with 'Nine Whys'](#)





Step 3: Develop Strategies With Critical Uncertainties

The Liberating Structure "Critical Uncertainties" is designed to develop strategies for dealing with a range of plausible yet unpredictable futures. It enables groups to quickly test the viability of current strategies and build their capacity to respond quickly to future challenges. When you use this structure, you become more resilient. It gives you the capacity to actively shape the system and be prepared to respond to change.

In the previous step, you clarified the purpose of the product. With Critical Uncertainties, you involve the Scrum Team and its stakeholders to develop a variety of product strategies to respond to the most critical and uncertain challenges you might face when creating the product.

Steps

Part 1 - Define the four scenarios 20 min

1. Use a virtual whiteboard to create the template for Critical Uncertainties. See the earlier shared illustration for an example.
2. 2 min Explain the overall purpose of Critical Uncertainties: to identify and explore the most critical potential futures and formulate strategies that will help you become successful in these different situations.
3. 2 min Ask the Scrum Team and the stakeholders to individually consider the factors that are very hard to predict or control their direction, and have the most impact on the success of the product. These factors could be internal (e.g. "Internal policy changes that impact our product", "Lack of funding") or external (e.g. "Level of demand from users" or "Competing products emerge"). Encourage everyone to write down examples for themselves.
4. 5 min Create groups of four and move them into breakouts. There, they quickly share their lists, remove duplicates, and add new ideas.
5. 5 min Together, collect all ideas on a shared workspace, prioritize the most critical factors using the question: "Which factors are the most critical to our ability to deliver a successful product?".
6. 5 min Select the top two factors and write each factor down one the axis as two extremes. For example, one axis represents the awareness of the product in the market and the other the degree to which comparable products exist.

This would make our two axes:

- X-Axis: Huge demand for the product – Nobody knows about our product
- Y-Axis: Many comparable products – No comparable products

Part 2 - Define the behavior for each scenario 20 min

1. 2 min By creating the two axes, four scenarios emerge. Take some time to briefly explain them. Prepare four breakout rooms, where each room is focused on one scenario. Each group takes a different scenario.
2. 10 min Explain that in their breakout, each group thinks about what the scenario they are sitting in looks like. What behavior might they observe? What would people say? How can you tell that this is going on? Ask the groups to write down approx. 10 potential observations for their scenario. Capture these ideas on yellow stickies on the virtual whiteboard.
3. 5 min Debrief some of the ideas with the entire group.

Part 3 - Give each scenario a name 10 min

1. 2 min Explain that in this step, the groups give their scenario a name that captures the essence. This could be a movie title (e.g. 'Love Boat', 'Endgame') or a quote (e.g. 'Shoot from the hip').
2. 5 min Move the groups into the breakouts (the same groups as in the previous round) and have them create a

- name for their scenario. Encourage them to first do this individually and then share it within their small group.
- 3 min With the entire group, ask everyone to share the names of their scenarios and write them in the middle of the quadrant.

Part 4 – Develop strategies to become successful 20 min

- 2 min Explain that in the following step each group is going to define strategies, experiments, and practices. Emphasize that each group does this for their own scenario. Ask: "Imagine that your scenario becomes a reality, what strategies would still help us deliver a successful product?".
- 10 min Move the groups into breakouts and have them define approx. 6 potential strategies, experiments, and practices. Encourage them to first do this individually and then share it within their small group.
- 5 min Debrief some of the ideas with the entire group.

Part 5 – Gallery Walk 10 min

- At this time, the template for Critical Uncertainties contains four scenarios (part 1), each filled with examples of behavior (part 2), a name that captures the essence (part 3), and strategies to become successful (part 4). Make sure the template is visible for everyone.
- 5 min Invite everyone to inspect the result individually, and in silence. Ask people to pay attention specifically to the strategies. Where do they notice similarities? Which strategies appear in multiple quadrants?
- 5 min Debrief by asking for examples of strategies that appeared in multiple quadrants. These are 'robust strategies' – they work in multiple scenarios and are the first thing to invest in. Other strategies may appear in only one quadrant but may avert disaster there ('hedging strategies'). Encourage everyone to pay attention to these types of strategies. For example, a robust strategy might be to invest significantly in marketing efforts and add marketing skills to the Scrum Team(s) – it will work well in many scenarios. A hedging strategy for a scenario where users are completely unaware of your product and there are many competing products might be to pivot the product drastically;

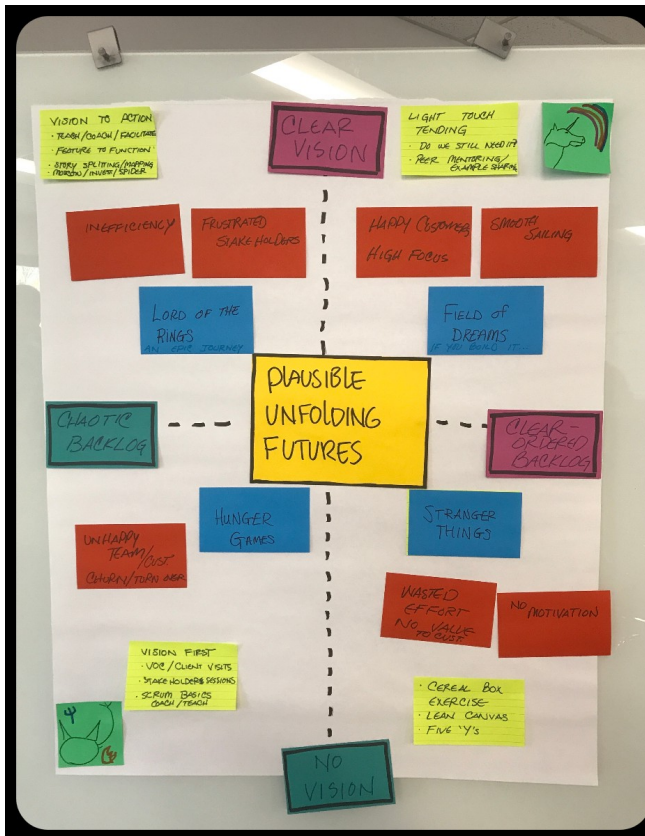
Our Findings

- The endpoints of the axes have to be clear, relevant, and truly opposites of each other. Unclear axes, or with very safe endpoints, take a lot of creativity out of the thinking. So really take the time to refine the axes.
- Do this exercise step-by-step. It can be an overwhelming, mind-crushing structure. Don't explain everything upfront. Allow them to focus on the content, don't get the groups distracted by the steps & rounds of the structure itself.
- Use 1–2–4–All in very short cycles for each step, especially the time for individual thinking and reflection is important
- Post-it notes with colored themes help with combining and recombining ideas. For example, yellow post-it's are used for the name of each scenario, blue for the strategies, etc

Resources

- The original article on [Critical Uncertainties](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Develop Strategies to Quickly Respond to Future Challenges with [Critical Uncertainties](#)







Step 4: Define Activities For The Most Valuable Strategies With 1-2-4-ALL

In the previous step, you used Critical Uncertainties to develop strategies for the most critical–yet–possible future scenarios for your product. It resulted in 'robust strategies', which work in scenarios and are the first thing to invest in. And 'hedging strategies', that may appear in only one quadrant but can avert disaster there.

In this step, you develop the most valuable strategies one step further with everyone present. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to quickly involve everyone in shaping the strategies and its next steps. The purpose here is not to exhaustively plan the various strategies, but just to get your bearings on what is most essential.

Invitation

"Which strategies should we invest in most of all in order to maximize our chance of successfully delivering a valuable product?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Collect the robust and hedging strategies in a shared workspace and ask the Scrum Team and the stakeholders to individually consider the strategies and connect their names to the ones they want to focus on.
2. **2 min** Distribute the participants in such a way, each strategy has a different group of participants connected to it. Obviously, you don't have to cover each strategy, pick the ones the group considers the most important. Ideally, a strategy has four participants connected to it.
3. **2 min** Ask everyone to first individually consider the activities, participants, and resources, that are necessary to realize the strategy they selected. Have them write it down for themselves as needed.
4. **5 min** Divide the group into pairs and move them into breakouts. There, they share their ideas and develop them further, together.
5. **8 min** Create groups of four, by keeping the pairs together and moving them into new breakouts. These groups all focus on the same strategy. Ask the groups to share their ideas, combine the lists, and add more detail.
6. **5 min** Together, collect all the activities, participants, and resources necessary to realize the strategy on a shared workspace. Remove duplicates, order the activities, and collect the next steps.

Our Findings

- As with all the steps in this string, don't fall into the temptation to create exhaustive lists. Whom do you need to involve right now? Who is most critical to your success? Start there and expand later.
- If you have more time, you can use Liberating Structures like ["Purpose to Practice"](#) or [Shift & Share](#) instead of 1-2-4-ALL to go deeper and broader.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)



Step 5: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

We always like to end on a personal note by asking people what it is that they want to contribute to the success of their Scrum team. No matter how small, if everyone makes one small change, together this generates large change. The Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) is super useful for this.

Steps

1. **3 min** Invite participants to take the scenario in mind they recognize the most and to write down a personal next step for this scenario. What is an improvement that they can make, without needing approval from someone else or resources they don't have access to? So, what are your 15% Solutions?
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partners find ways to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).
3. **5 min** Debrief with the entire group and give people the opportunity to share their 15% Solutions.

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

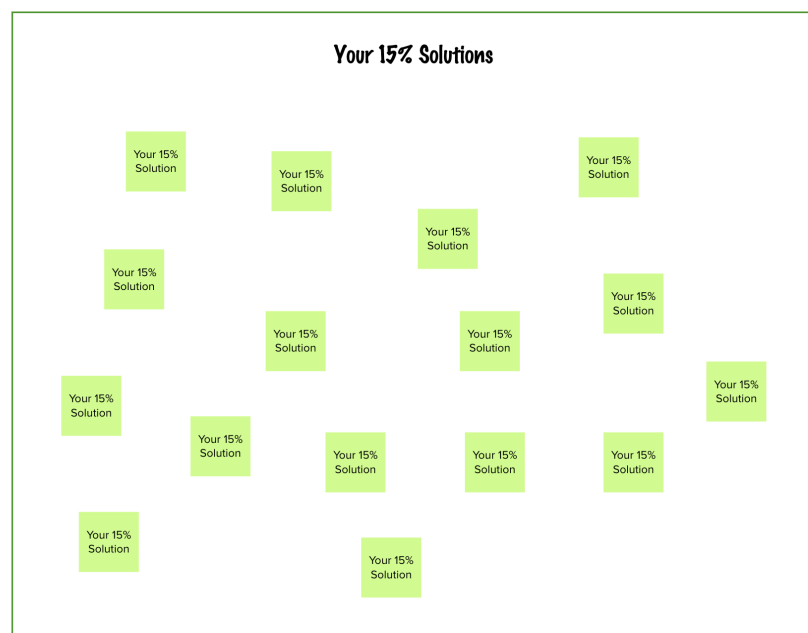
Step 1

Position yourself in the scenario you recognize the most and write down a personal next step.

What is an improvement that you can make, without needing approval from someone else or resources you don't have access to?

Step 2

Pair up and share your 15% Solution while giving and getting help to refine your next step



Step 6: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this meetup?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!

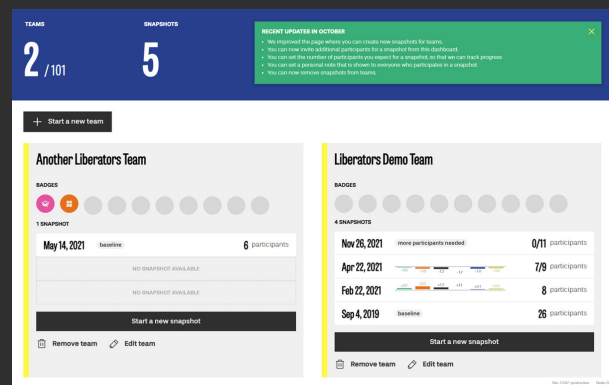
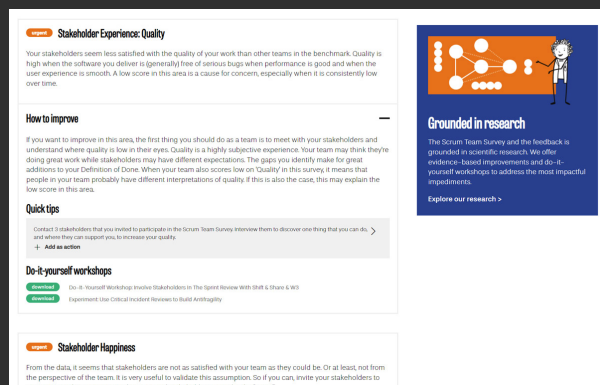
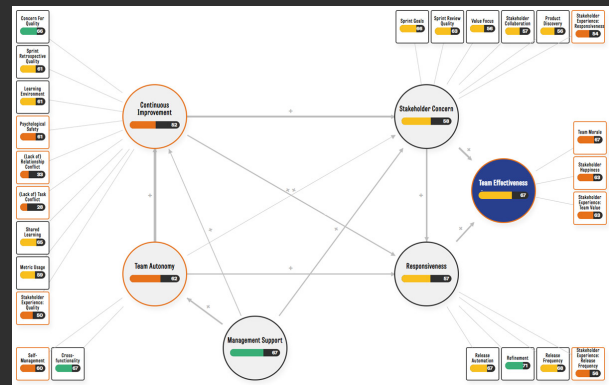
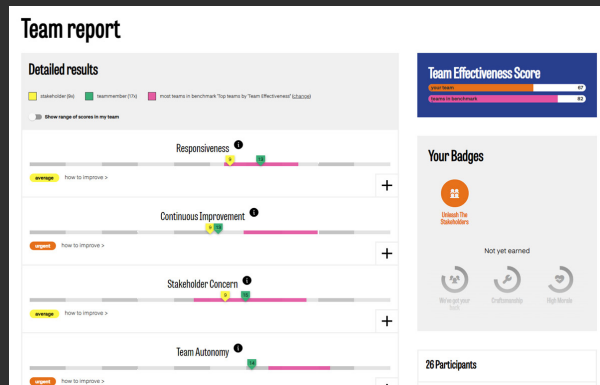
More resources to improve collaboration with stakeholders

- Actual stakeholders? Or just your audience? Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Myth: Only The Product Owner Interacts With Stakeholders. Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Involve Stakeholders](#)
- Podcast: [The Curious Case of the Missing Stakeholders](#)



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

Unleashing Teams All Over The World

We are The Liberators – Barry Overeem and Christiaan Verwijs. Our mission is to create data-driven products to unleash the superpowers of teams all over the world. We do this together with a growing community of patrons.

Awesome content for awesome teams

We unleash teams with our [blogposts](#), our [podcast](#), our [newsletter](#), our [videos](#), and our frequent [meetups](#). While we offer most of this for free, we also have plenty of premium content in [our webshop](#) for you to explore.

Supported by the community

We are super proud that The Liberators is almost entirely funded by the community. If you appreciate our work too, you can already support us for 12 dollars/year by becoming a [patron](#). In return, you gain free access to premium content, we share our work-in-progress and involve you in creating more awesome content.



Thank you for respecting our work!

We work hard to create high-quality content that puts you in a position to unleash your team. We're sure you appreciate that a lot of our time and money goes into this. At the same time, content like this is our main source of income. It's what pays our bills :)

If you purchased this content, we ask only that you treat our work with respect and don't share it with people outside your team. If you stumbled on it elsewhere without paying for it, and it offers you value, would you consider [supporting us too](#)? You can also check [out our other offerings](#).